CHAPTER 9 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

Three Plans for Peace

The war was won. Now came a harder question: on what terms would the nation be put back together? 1865–1867.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

The war was won. Now came a harder question: on what terms would the nation be put back together? 1865–1867.

After a civil war, who decides the peace — and should the goal be to forgive quickly, or to remake what was broken?

“With Malice Toward None”

LINCOLN'S PLAN

Even before the war ended, Lincoln offered a lenient path back. His Ten Percent Plan said that once just 10% of a state's voters swore loyalty to the Union, the state could form a new government and rejoin.

His aim was speed and reconciliation — to “bind up the nation's wounds.” But Lincoln was assassinated before he could put a full plan in place, leaving the question wide open.

Andrew Johnson

THE ACCIDENTAL PRESIDENT

A Southern Unionist from Tennessee, Johnson became president when Lincoln died. He claimed Lincoln's mantle of leniency — but used it to protect the old white Southern order.

Andrew Johnson — photograph, Brady–Handy Collection, public domain (Library of Congress).

Leniency for the Old Order

JOHNSON'S PLAN

Andrew Johnson went further than Lincoln in forgiving the white South. He pardoned former Confederates freely and let Southern states rebuild their governments with few conditions.

The result alarmed the North: the new Southern governments passed Black Codes to control freedpeople, and sent former Confederate leaders right back to Congress. To many Northerners, it looked like the South was losing the war but winning the peace.

The five military districts, 1867 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

A Second Founding

THE RADICAL PLAN

A group of Republicans in Congress — the Radical Republicans, led by Thaddeus Stevens and Charles Sumner — had a bolder vision. They wanted to remake the South: protect the rights of freedpeople, guarantee Black citizenship and the vote, and keep ex-Confederates out of power.

Some even called for land redistribution — the famous promise of "forty acres and a mule." Where Johnson wanted to restore the old South, the Radicals wanted to build a new one.

THADDEUS STEVENS, RADICAL REPUBLICAN · 1865

The whole fabric of southern society must be changed … Without this, this government can never be, as it never has been, a true republic.

Three Roads, One Choice

WHY IT MATTERS

These were not just three policies — they were three different answers to what the war had meant. Was it fought only to restore the Union? Or to build a new nation founded on equality?

The clash between Johnson and the Radicals would dominate the next years — and decide whether the promises of freedom would be written into law, or quietly abandoned.

Compare the Plans

YOUR TURN

You'll put the three plans side by side and practice comparison — judging how each would have answered the hardest questions of Reconstruction.